

1615-1868

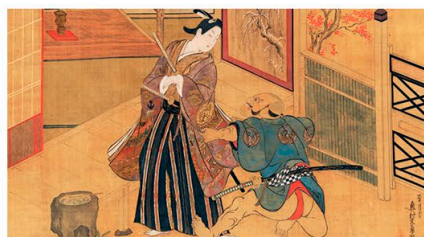
THE FLOATING WORLD

After centuries of civil strife, in the 17th century Japan entered an era of almost continuous peace under the rule of the Tokugawa shogunate. Establishing their capital at Edo (now Tokyo), the shoguns firmly controlled the regional warlords (the *daimyo*) who had once fought for power. The court of the Japanese emperors at Kyoto was relegated to decorative irrelevance. The samurai warriors, Japan's traditional fighting class, survived as paid retainers of the *daimyo*, without a function.

In conditions of peace and order, Japan's economic life flourished. Although despised in a social order that ranked them below peasants, merchants grew rich on commerce even though foreign trade was

strictly controlled. Japanese craft workers and artists flourished, serving an elite that increasingly gathered in towns and cities. By the late 17th century, Japan was among the world's most urbanized countries and Edo, with a population of around a million, may have been the largest city anywhere. A vibrant urban culture, dubbed the "Floating World", absorbed the money of the merchant class and the leisure time of idle samurai devoted to pleasure instead of warfare.

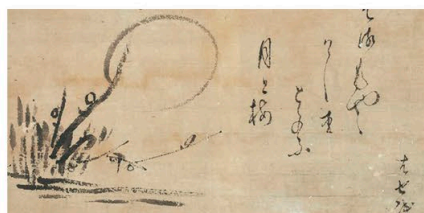
Despite mounting problems with peasant revolts and plots by discontented samurai, the Tokugawa shogunate sustained a stable society for more than 250 years, before pressure from Western imperialism triggered fundamental change.



KEY MOMENTS

1629 All-male kabuki

With their melodrama, ribaldry, and flamboyant costumes, Kabuki plays (depicted left) became extremely popular in urban Japan. From 1629, female performers were banned, so male actors enacted both men's and women's roles.

**1689 Bashō's journey**

Tokugawa Japan's literary culture included the haiku verse form. In 1689, the haiku poet Matsuo Bashō (1644-94), journeyed into remote northern Honshu, recording his experiences in his masterwork *The Narrow Road to the Deep North* (left).

**1829-32 Hokusai's Thirty-Six Views**

The series of woodblock prints of Mount Fuji (left) by Katsushika Hokusai (1760-1849) are among the most famous Japanese artworks of the late Tokugawa period. When examples of Hokusai's prints began to filter through to Europe in the 1860s, they had a decisive influence on the evolution of Western art.

